

Suggest and recommend

Learner workbook

Offer an idea using a natural verb pattern.

Understand the distinction

Use suggest or recommend with a noun or an -ing activity: suggest a cafe; recommend booking early. With a named person doing the action, a that clause is useful: I suggest that she book early. She should book is also possible after that, especially in British English.

Do not use suggest someone to do for advice. Say suggest that someone do, or suggest doing. Recommend has additional patterns and meanings, such as recommend someone for a job. Learn the meaning and pattern together instead of treating both verbs as identical in every use.

Compare the patterns

ACTIVITY

I recommend booking ahead.

Booking is the suggested activity.

PERSON + ACTION

I suggest that Mina call first.

Use the base verb call in this advice pattern.

RECIPIENT

She suggested a cafe to me.

To me identifies the recipient of the suggestion.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the correction: She suggested me to apply.

- A. She suggested that I apply.
- B. She suggested that I to apply.
- C. She suggested to me to apply.

2. Complete: I recommend ___ early. (arrive)

- A. arriving
- B. arrive
- C. to arriving

3. Is I suggest that she should call possible?

- A. Yes, especially in British English.
- B. Yes, but only when giving advice about the past.
- C. No. Should is forbidden after suggest.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which recommendation uses a standard suggest pattern?

A. I suggest taking an earlier train so you have time to find the office.

B. I suggest that you to take an earlier train.

C. I suggest you should taking an earlier train.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. She suggested that I apply.

Suggest does not use the person + to-infinitive advice pattern.

2. A. arriving

Use an -ing form for the activity.

3. A. Yes, especially in British English.

Should + base verb is an accepted alternative.

4. A. I suggest taking an earlier train so you have time to find the office.

Suggest can take an -ing form: taking.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-17.html